



The groundlings often heckled the players, shouting vulgar comments and throwing apples if they got bored

SHABBY SCARECROWS

The people who stood in the yard were called "groundlings" by the richer members of the audience. They were also nicknamed "scarecrows" because of their shabby appearance, or "stinkards" because of the way they smelled. They were sweaty and dirty, and people complained about their smelly breath.

Crowds of stinkards would sometimes start fights and riots – even the actors on the stage were not safe when they went on the rampage

"Your stinkard has the self-same liberty to be there in his tobacco fumes which your sweet courtier hath."

THOMAS DEKKER
The Gull's Hornbook, 1609

According to the accounts of some theatregoers, groundlings stank of garlic and onions



Garlic cloves

Money was carried in a purse dangling from a belt because few clothes at the time had pockets



THEATER THIEVES

Playgoers risked being robbed by a cutpurse. Stealing from groundlings in the crowded yard was easiest. But some thieves dressed as gentlemen to avoid attracting attention and worked in the galleries, where the richest pickings were to be found.



Tankards were usually made from either pewter or wood



GETTING MERRY

Groundlings guzzled ale from tankards, like the one above, but the gallery crowd preferred wine. In several plays, Shakespeare's characters drink a strong Spanish wine called sack. In *The Merry Wives of Windsor*, Sir John Falstaff says that if he had a thousand sons he would teach them all to "addict themselves to sack."

COMFORT COSTS

It cost one penny to stand in the yard to watch a play. For an extra penny, playgoers could sit in one of the gallery seats. A cushioned seat in the gentlemen's rooms cost three pennies.



Coin found at the Rose playhouse